Social Media and Political Attitudes among University Students: A Quantitative Analysis

Introduction

Social media has become an important part of political communication, changing how political information is shared and how citizens interact with political actors. Platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, and Twitter have provided new opportunities for political engagement, particularly among younger generations (Garner, Ferdinand & Lawson, 2020). Political parties and candidates increasingly use these platforms to communicate their messages and reach younger voters through interactive posts and campaign content. Furthermore, these platforms help raise awareness of political and social issues and mobilise people for collective action, including protests, regardless of geographical distance. By enabling real-time communication, they facilitate the coordination of demonstrations and social movements (Hague et al., 2020). Activists and social movements also use these platforms to reach wider audiences and encourage political participation, particularly among young people. As a result, social media offers opportunities for political discussion and engagement, allowing individuals to express their opinions and organise collective activities more easily (Garner et al., 2020).

Despite these opportunities, young people's increasing exposure to online information also raises concerns about misinformation, confusion, and information overload. The spread of fake news highlights the importance of critically evaluating information obtained through social media (Hague et al., 2020). Social media users often seek information that aligns with their existing beliefs and preferences. This phenomenon is commonly referred to as an echo chamber, in which individuals are primarily exposed to information and opinions that reinforce their existing beliefs, while alternative perspectives receive limited attention (Hague et al., 2020). Ferguson (2022) suggests that young people may become increasingly

confined within their own echo chambers, reinforcing one-sided political perspectives and contributing to political polarisation in online discussions.

The main purpose of this study is to examine the relationship between social media and young people's political attitudes and behaviour, as perceived by university students. More specifically, the study investigates whether students' perceptions of social media as a source of political information are associated with their perceptions of its influence on political attitudes and voting behaviour. It also examines whether these perceptions differ between male and female respondents.

Methodology

The original study employed both qualitative and quantitative methods, including semi-structured interviews and a questionnaire. The present analysis focuses on the quantitative data collected through the questionnaire. Data were collected between December 2023 and January 2024 from 50 students enrolled in the Department of Political Sciences at Aristotle University of Thessaloniki, Greece. The questionnaire included questions concerning students' characteristics, social media use, political information, and perceptions of social media's influence on political attitudes and behaviour.

The questionnaire responses were recorded and analysed using IBM SPSS Statistics to investigate relationships between the variables under examination. Descriptive statistics were used to summarise the characteristics of the sample and participants' responses. Spearman's rank correlation was employed to examine associations between ordinal variables measuring perceptions of the political role of social media. In addition, a Mann–Whitney U test was conducted to investigate whether male and female respondents differed in their perceptions of social media's influence on voting behaviour. Tables were used to present the findings and facilitate their interpretation.

Results

Sample Characteristics

Table 1. Gender Distribution of Respondents

Table 1

Gender

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Male	25	50.0	50.0	50.0
	Female	25	50.0	50.0	100.0
	Total	50	100.0	100.0	

The participants were asked to provide information about their gender. As shown in Table 1, all 50 students answered this question, with no missing responses. Of the 50 participants, 25 were male, and 25 were female. Therefore, the sample was equally divided between the two genders, each representing 50% of the respondents.

Table 2. Spearman's Rank Correlation Between Political Information and Perceived Political Influence of Social Media

Table 2

Correlations

			Young People Use Social Media for Political Information	Social Media Content Influences Young People's Political Attitudes and Behaviour
Spearman's rho	Young People Use Social Media for Political Information	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	.595***
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	<.001
		N	50	50
	Social Media Content Influences Young People's Political Attitudes and Behaviour	Correlation Coefficient	.595***	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	.
		N	50	50

***. Correlation is significant at the 0.001 level (2-tailed).

To explore the relationship between political information and attitudes, Spearman's rank correlation was calculated using two questionnaire statements. The first asks whether young people use social media to get political information, while the second asks whether the content they encounter influences their political attitudes and behaviour.

The results showed a positive correlation between the two statements ($\rho = 0.595$, $p < 0.001$, $N = 50$), as presented in Table 2. This indicates that students who agreed more strongly that young people use social media for political information also tended to agree more strongly that it influences political attitudes and behaviour. Similarly, respondents who were less inclined to agree with the first statement generally tended to express lower levels of agreement with the second.

This finding suggests that students' perceptions of the informational role of social media are associated with their perceptions of its political influence. However, this correlation reflects an association between respondents' views and does not establish that obtaining political information through social media directly causes changes in political attitudes or behaviour.

Table 3. Spearman's Rank Correlation Between Social Media as the Main Source of Political Information and Perceived Influence on Voting Behaviour

Table 3

Correlations

			Social Media Are the Main Source of Political Information for Young People	Young People Vote Largely Based on Messages Received Through Social Media
Spearman's rho	Social Media Are the Main Source of Political Information for Young People	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	.503***
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	<.001
		N	50	50
	Young People Vote Largely Based on Messages Received Through Social Media	Correlation Coefficient	.503***	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	.
		N	50	50

***. Correlation is significant at the 0.001 level (2-tailed).

A second Spearman's rank correlation was conducted to examine the relationship between students' perceptions of social media as the main source of political information for young people and their perceived influence on voting behaviour.

As presented in Table 3, the results indicated a positive and statistically significant correlation between the two variables ($\rho = 0.503$, $p < 0.001$, $N = 50$). This suggests that respondents who expressed stronger agreement with the statement that social media constitute the main source of political information for young people also tended to agree more strongly that young people vote largely based on messages received through these platforms.

Overall, the findings indicate a statistically significant association between these two perceptions. However, these findings reflect respondents' perceptions and do not establish that social media directly influences young people's voting decisions.

4. Gender Differences in Perceived Social Media Influence on Voting Behaviour

Table 4

Ranks

	Gender	N	Mean Rank	Sum of Ranks
Young People Vote Largely Based on Messages Received Through Social Media	Male	25	26.66	666.50
	Female	25	24.34	608.50
	Total	50		

Test Statistics[a]

	Young People Vote Largely Based on Messages Received Through Social Media
Mann-Whitney U	283.500
Wilcoxon W	608.500
Z	-.595
Asymp. Sig. (2-tailed)	.552

a. Grouping Variable: Gender

A Mann–Whitney U test was conducted to examine whether male and female respondents differed in their perceptions of social media's influence on young people's voting behaviour. The analysis included 25 male and 25 female students.

As shown in Table 4, male respondents had a slightly higher mean rank (26.66) than female respondents (24.34). However, the difference was not statistically significant ($U = 283.50$, $Z = -0.595$, $p = 0.552$).

The results therefore provide insufficient evidence that male and female students differed in their responses to this statement.

Conclusion

This study examined university students' perceptions of the relationship between social media and young people's political attitudes and voting behaviour. Using questionnaire data from 50 Political Science students at Aristotle University of Thessaloniki, the analysis explored associations between perceptions of social media as a source of political information and its perceived political influence.

The results revealed two positive and statistically significant correlations. Students who agreed that young people use social media for political information also tended to believe that content on these platforms influences political attitudes and behaviour. A similar relationship was observed between perceptions of social media as the main source of political information and its influence on voting decisions. In contrast, the Mann–Whitney U test did not identify a statistically significant difference between male and female respondents in their perceptions of social media's influence on voting behaviour.

These findings should be interpreted with caution. The study was based on a relatively small sample of students from a single university department, which limits the generalisability of the results. Furthermore, the questionnaire primarily measured respondents'

perceptions rather than their actual voting behaviour, and the observed correlations do not establish causal relationships.

Overall, the study highlights the perceived importance of social media in political information and electoral behaviour among young people. Future research involving larger and more diverse samples could provide further insight into how social media use relates to political attitudes and participation.

References

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